The Education of a Citizenry: Hope, Demobilization, and Authoritarian Normalization in Cambodia, 2008–2021

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Introduction

In 2012, Cambodians rated the democratic future of their country at 9.58 out of 10.

It is worth pausing on that number. On a scale designed to capture the full range of democratic expectation, Cambodian respondents placed themselves at the extreme ceiling—more optimistic about their democratic

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trajectory than citizens of virtually any other country surveyed by the Asian Barometer (Hu et al. 2023). This was not a country with free and fair elections, an independent judiciary, or a vibrant free press. It was a dominant-party authoritarian state under the continuous rule of Hun Sen and the Cambodian People's Party (CPP), a regime that had held power since 1985 and showed no signs of voluntary departure. And yet Cambodians believed, with remarkable consistency, that democracy was coming.

Nine years later, that same measure had fallen to 6.7 out of 10. In the same period, independent civic engagement—contacting influential figures outside the state, discussing politics, attending to political news—had collapsed to historic lows, even as participation through officially sanctioned channels quietly rose. Acceptance of authoritarian governance alternatives, including strongman rule, single-party rule, expert rule, and military rule, had risen sharply. Reported encounters with corruption had plummeted from 49 percent to 15 percent. And voter turnout in national elections, now conducted without any viable opposition, had paradoxically climbed to 88 percent.

What happened in between is the subject of this article. The answer, stated plainly, is that the Cambodian People's Party dissolved the only credible opposition party, the Cambodia National Rescue Party (CNRP), in November 2017—and simultaneously dismantled the independent media, civil society organizations, and informal networks through which citizens had accessed alternative political information and organized collective action. The combined effect coincided with a remarkably coherent adjustment in Cambodian citizens' attitudes, behaviors, and expectations—one that matches the predicted signature of *demobilization by subtraction* across multiple survey dimensions simultaneously. This article argues that this adjustment is best understood not as a story of

authoritarian consolidation in the conventional sense—not as the triumph of ideology, coercion, or performance legitimacy—but as something quieter and, in its way, more profound: the education of a citizenry in the limits of the politically possible.

The phenomenon under investigation—the systematic elimination of organized opposition within an otherwise functioning electoral system—has become increasingly common, from Turkey's suppression of the Peoples' Democratic Party to Russia's dismantling of Navalny's organizational network. Yet existing scholarship has focused on the institutional mechanics of opposition elimination rather than its downstream effects on mass political orientations. This article proposes that opposition elimination produces a distinctive observable signature: synchronized, multi-domain shifts concentrated in the political domain, with the critical diagnostic being a divergence between rising electoral turnout and collapsing independent civic engagement—elections transformed from mechanisms of political choice into rituals of regime compliance. If this signature proves generalizable, it offers a framework for identifying democratic closure using existing cross-national survey infrastructure.

The article is organized around the four survey waves as acts in a political sequence. This is a deliberate methodological choice. Cambodia's trajectory between 2008 and 2021 is both analytically tractable—the survey data capture discrete moments in a well-documented closure—and narratively coherent, with each wave mapping onto a distinct phase of political life. The sections that follow narrate a documented political sequence; the causal claims are the survey data's to make or withhold, not the narrative's.

The question of how dominant-party regimes endure has generated a rich vocabulary in comparative politics—skewed playing fields, menus of

manipulation, the stabilizing pillars of legitimation, repression, and co-optation.[1] Yet this institutional focus, vital for understanding the resilience of the state, obscures the downstream effects on the citizenry. Theories of regime survival treat the public as a variable to be managed—repressed into submission or bought off through patronage. This article asks a different question: what happens to citizen orientations when the democratic alternative is systematically removed? The resulting quiescence, it argues, is not a product of active authoritarian legitimation but of demobilization by subtraction.

The concept advanced here—demobilization by subtraction—is distinct from repression and co-optation, the two mechanisms most commonly invoked to explain political quiescence under authoritarianism (Figure 1).[2][3] Both presuppose an active regime strategy directed at the population. Subtraction operates differently: its proximate cause is an action taken against the political field itself—the removal of the credible alternative around which civic mobilization had organized—rather than against citizens directly. The result is not fear-based withdrawal or interest-based compliance but something closer to what Gaventa termed "quiescence": the internalization of powerlessness following the sustained absence of viable channels for political expression.[4] Where Lukes' third dimension of power shapes preferences so that grievances never form,

[1] For the foundational typologies of these institutional survival mechanics, see Levitsky and Way (2010); Schedler (2013); and Gerschewski (2013). While these frameworks masterfully explain elite-level regime consolidation, they are less equipped to explain the simultaneous, multi-dimensional shifts in mass public opinion observed in the Asian Barometer Survey data during periods of opposition collapse.
[2] On repression as a mechanism of demobilization, see Davenport (2007); Davenport et al. (2005); Earl (2011).
[3] The co-optation framework is developed most fully in Gandhi (2008). On the equilibrium logic of authoritarian power-sharing, see Przeworski et al. (2000).
[4] Gaventa's central insight—that sustained powerlessness produces not resistance but the internalization of quiescence—provides the closest existing theoretical analogue to the pattern observed in the Cambodian data (Gaventa 1980).

demobilization by subtraction operates one step later—grievances may persist, but the perceived vehicle for their expression has been eliminated.[5]

Figure 1 maps the observable implications of each mechanism. The Cambodian data are consistent with the subtraction signature and inconsistent with the pure repression signature on both counts. Subtraction is expected to dominate when the opposition served as the primary focal organization for civic coordination and when repression is selective rather than generalized—both conditions Cambodia satisfies.

The remainder of this article proceeds as follows. A data section describes the ABS waves, measures, and cross-wave comparability. Four analytic sections trace the survey evidence through pre-mobilization (2008), peak mobilization (2012), selective retreat (2015), and post-dissolution normalization (2021). A section on alternative mechanisms adjudicates competing explanations, and a concluding section draws out theoretical implications.

[5]The distinction matters: Lukes' third dimension operates *before* grievances form; demobilization by subtraction operates *after* grievances have formed and been politically activated, removing the vehicle for their expression rather than the grievances themselves (Lukes 2005).

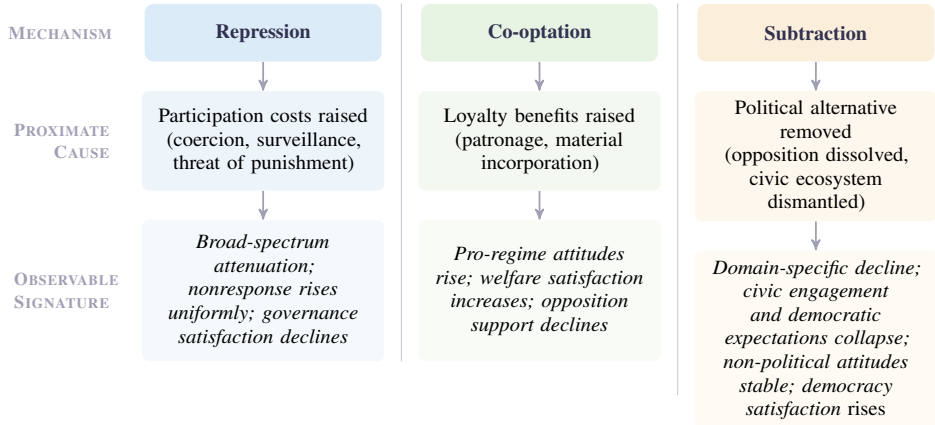

Figure 1. Three mechanisms of political demobilization: causal pathways and observable implications. The subtraction mechanism is distinguished from repression and co-optation by the locus of regime action (the political field rather than the citizenry directly) and by a domain-specific rather than broad-spectrum observable signature. The Cambodian data are consistent with the subtraction column and inconsistent with the repression and co-optation columns on both the placebo battery and the democracy satisfaction trajectory.

Data, Measures, and Comparability

This article draws on the Asian Barometer Survey [ABS; Asian Barometer Survey (2023)][6] a repeated cross-sectional survey program administered across East and Southeast Asia since 2001.

[6]Data analyzed in this article were collected by the Asian Barometer Project (2005–2008, 2010–2012, 2013–2016, 2020–2022), co-directed by Professors Fu Hu, Yun-han Chu, and Min-hua Huang, with major funding support from Taiwan's Ministry of Education, the National Science and Technology Council, Academia Sinica, and National Taiwan University. The Asian Barometer Project Office (www.asianbarometer.org) is solely responsible for data distribution. The views expressed herein are the author's own. Cambodia has been included in four of the six completed waves: Wave 2 (fielded 2008, N = 1,000), Wave 3 (2012, N = 1,200), Wave 4 (2015, N = 1,200), and Wave 6 (2021, N = 1,242). Cambodia was not included in Wave 1 (2001–2003) or Wave 5 (2018–2019); the latter omission is particularly consequential, as it means no ABS data exist from the immediate aftermath of the CNRP dissolution and the 2018 one-party election. The survey's Wave 5 fieldwork period coincided with the immediate aftermath of the forced dissolution of the CNRP in November 2017 and the July 2018 national election in which the CPP ran virtually unopposed—conditions under which credible public opinion research could not be conducted. The absence of Wave 5 is thus not an artifact of research design but a reflection of the political closure this study documents: the very phenomenon under investigation rendered standard survey fieldwork untenable. This gap means the analysis cannot observe the immediate post-dissolution period directly, a limitation addressed below through adjudication tests designed to distinguish between an acute fear response and the longer-term normalization pattern proposed here. The four available waves nevertheless bracket the critical political sequence: pre-mobilization (2008), peak mobilization (2012), post-crackdown selective retreat (2015), and post-dissolution normalization (2021).

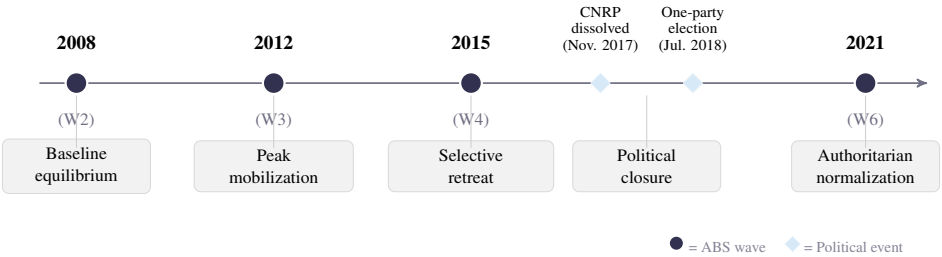

Figure 2. The political sequence, 2008–2021. Filled circles mark Asian Barometer Survey waves; diamonds mark key political events. The analysis is organised around four phases defined by the relationship between the Cambodia National Rescue Party and the political field: pre-mobilization baseline (2008), peak mobilization (2012), selective retreat (2015), and post-dissolution normalization (2021). The six-year gap between Wave 4 and Wave 6 encompasses the critical closure sequence.

The ABS employs face-to-face interviews with nationally representative probability samples; response rates across the four Cambodian waves range from approximately 80 to 90 percent.[7]

Supplementary Data—The 2017 Cambodia Socio-Economic Survey

The ABS data are supplemented by a single cross-section from the Cambodia Socio-Economic Survey (SES), a nationally representative household survey administered by the National Institute of Statistics. The SES wave employed here (deposited with the World Bank Microdata Library as KHM_2018_SAIE_v01; N = 3,363) was collected through face-to-face interviews with an inferred fieldwork period of early-to-mid 2017, placing the survey in the final months before the intensification of political closure.[8]

[7]Cambodian samples are stratified by province and urban/rural classification, with primary sampling units selected proportional to population size and households via random walk procedures within enumeration areas. The survey instrument is administered in Khmer. No post-stratification weights are applied; samples are treated as self-weighting, following ABS standard practice for single-country analyses. On ABS methodology and sampling design generally, see Chu et al. (2008); country-level details are in the ABS Technical Report for each wave.

[8]The fieldwork period is inferred from internal temporal references: the questionnaire references the 2016–17 school year as current, the 2016 commune budget as the most recently completed fiscal cycle, and "additional money paid to officials in 2016" as a retrospective question about the immediately preceding year. This places

Six governance items from the SES are relevant to the present analysis: perceived responsiveness of commune councillors and village chiefs (binary agree/disagree), perceived freedom of speech and freedom of association at the commune level (binary), perceived freedom to vote for any party without fear (binary), and reported payment of "tea money"—the Cambodian vernacular for petty bribery—to government officials in 2016 (binary). These items are not directly comparable to the ABS instruments in scale or sampling design, and are not treated as equivalent measures. Their value is triangulative: they establish the state of perceived civic freedom and corruption exposure in the immediate pre-dissolution period, a window the ABS does not cover. The SES data are reported in Appendix D.

Detailed SES governance modules were not publicly available for the 2018–2020 fieldwork period; a phone-based COVID-focused survey conducted in 2020 carried no political orientation or corruption items. The absence of detailed governance survey data during the years immediately following the CNRP dissolution is consistent with the broader pattern of political closure documented in this article.

The analysis tracks five thematic domains across waves. For each domain, the specific indicators, scale constructions, and cross-wave comparability considerations are as follows.

Political participation. Six participation items are tracked as gate proportions—the share of the full sample reporting ever having engaged in each activity. Of these, contacting influential persons and attending demonstrations employ consistent wording across all four waves and are treated as fully comparable; cross-wave comparability for other items is

collection after the collapse of the Culture of Dialogue but before Kem Sokha's arrest in September 2017 and the CNRP dissolution in November 2017.

documented in the appendix (Table A1).[9] Community leader contact frequency (1–5 scale) and self-reported voter turnout (binary) supplement the gate items.

Authoritarian governance preferences. Four items assess respondent evaluations of non-democratic governance alternatives: single-party rule, strongman rule, military rule, and expert rule. Each is measured on a consistent 1–4 scale (1 = "very bad," 4 = "very good") across all waves in which the item appears. Expert rule was not fielded in Wave 2. These items are among the most stable in the ABS instrument, with identical wording and response options across waves.

Democratic Orientations

The analysis tracks four analytically separable dimensions of democratic attitudes, following the growing recognition that "democratic support" is not a unitary construct (Bratton et al. 2004; Mattes and Bratton 2007): abstract commitment (forced-choice democracy preference and an agree/disagree evaluative item), practical prioritization (a democracy-vs-equality trade-off), satisfaction with how democracy works (1–4 scale, identical wording all four waves), and feasibility expectations (0–10 past/present/future ratings, Waves 3, 4, and 6 only).[10] The

[9]The ABS participation battery employs a two-part structure: a gate question ("Have you ever done X?") asked of all respondents, followed by a frequency question asked only of those who answer affirmatively. This article reports gate proportions rather than frequency means, which are conditional on participation and based on much smaller subsamples. The elected official and civil servant contact items use a narrower, problem-motivated framing in Wave 3 ("to complain about or seek help with a problem") that differs from the broader framing in Waves 2, 4, and 6; cross-wave comparisons involving Wave 3 for these items are flagged accordingly. Petitions, demonstrations, and media contact were not fielded in Wave 2.

[10]*Commitment item 1* (all four waves): forced choice among "democracy is always preferable," "authoritarian government can sometimes be preferable," and "it doesn't matter" (coded 1–3). *Commitment item 2* (Waves 3–6): "democracy may have its problems but it is still the best form of government" (1–4 agree/disagree; nonresponse under 2 percent in Waves 3–4, rising to 10–13 percent in Wave 6). *Prioritization* (Waves 3, 4, 6): five-point trade-off between political freedom and economic equality; a second trade-off pitting democracy against economic development is available all four waves but is empirically less dynamic and reported in Appendix Table A10. *Corruption*: witnessed corruption is a binary indicator; Wave 2 wording is narrower than Waves 3–6 and treated with caution. Perceived national and local government corruption on consistent 1–4 scales.

expectations items carry the highest nonresponse—63 percent on democratic future in Wave 6—and are treated as supporting evidence for patterns established more robustly on the commitment, prioritization, and satisfaction measures. The nonresponse rate is itself analytically informative and is addressed in the alternative mechanisms section.

Table 1 summarizes the comparability status of the headline indicators.

Table 1. Cross-Wave Comparability of Headline Indicators

Variable	Status	Notes
Contacted influential person	Full	
Demonstration attendance	Full	
Single-party rule (1–4)	Full	Not fielded W2
Strongman rule (1–4)	Full	Not fielded W2
Democracy always preferable	Full	Not fielded W2
Democracy satisfaction (1–4)	Full	
Democratic future (0–10)	Full*	Not fielded W2; 63% NR in W6
Democracy vs. equality (1–5)	Full	Not fielded W2
Witnessed corruption (binary)	Partial	W2 wording narrower
Contacted civil servant	Partial	W3 wording differs
Contacted elected official	Partial	W3 wording differs
Internet news frequency	Partial	Scale harmonized

Note: Full = identical or functionally equivalent wording across all waves in which the item appears. Partial = minor wording shift or response scale change requiring caution in cross-wave comparison. Full* = wording consistent but elevated nonresponse in later waves limits inferential strength. Full detail in Appendix Table A1.

Analytic strategy. The analysis is primarily descriptive: wave-level means and proportions with 95 percent confidence intervals (Wilson intervals for proportions; t-based for means), evaluated with two-sample t-tests or proportion tests.[11] Covariate-adjusted OLS models are reported in Table 2 as a compositional robustness check, confirming that headline patterns are

Media and interest: political interest, news following, and political discussion on consistent 1–4 or 1–3 scales; internet news harmonized to a 1–6 frequency scale across waves with differing original response categories.

[11]This design cannot establish causality in the formal sense, but can identify whether the timing, direction, and domain-specificity of observed shifts are consistent with the demobilization-by-subtraction mechanism and

not explained by demographic differences across survey samples. The analytic leverage derives from within-case temporal variation across a well-documented political sequence; the alternative mechanisms section addresses causal adjudication directly.

Table 2. OLS Wave Coefficients With Demographic Controls

	Dem. future (0–10)	Dem. satisfaction (1–4)	Dem. preference (binary)
Wave 4	-1.858 (0.120)***	-0.264 (0.031)***	0.131 (0.021)***
Wave 6	-2.887 (0.128)***	0.137 (0.031)***	0.046 (0.022)*
Wave 3	NA	0.009 (0.031)	-0.043 (0.021)*

Note: OLS regression. All models include age, gender, education, and urbanicity as controls. Reference wave: W3 for democratic future; W2 for satisfaction and preference. Cell format: coefficient (SE). * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$. Full models with freedom-perception controls and attenuation estimates in Appendix Table A6.

The Quiet Kingdom: Cambodia in 2008

The first act of this story is a silence, and it is important to understand what kind of silence it was.[12]

By 2008, Cambodia had been under continuous CPP rule for over two decades. The party had consolidated its dominance through a patronage network linking the central state to village-level administration, an integrated security apparatus, a compliant judiciary, and GDP growth averaging about 7 percent annually—the material foundation for the regime's implicit bargain of stability in exchange for political acquiescence (Blake 2019; Morgenbesser 2016; World Bank 2026). The opposition was fragmented: the Sam Rainsy Party commanded a loyal but limited urban constituency; the Human Rights Party, led by Kem Sokha, lacked the organizational reach to threaten CPP hegemony. Neither posed

inconsistent with plausible alternatives. The analytic strategy treats the Cambodian sequence as a structured comparison across a documented political closure rather than as a natural experiment.

[12]Unless otherwise noted, the political chronology and electoral data in this section draw on Hughes (2010); Strangio (2014); Un (2013a); and Un (2013b)

a credible challenge in isolation—a structural condition that would change dramatically with their merger four years later (Norén-Nilsson 2015).

The Wave 2 Asian Barometer data from this period paint a portrait of a population that was neither enthusiastic nor resistant, but simply quiet.[13] Political participation was present but low in intensity: 43 percent of respondents reported ever having contacted a person of influence, yet community leader contact averaged just 1.53 on a five-point frequency scale.[14]

[13]Unless otherwise noted, the following scale conventions apply throughout: gate participation items are reported as the percentage of respondents who ever engaged in each activity (binary: ever vs. never); community leader contact is reported as a mean on a 1–5 scale (1 = never, 5 = often); authoritarian governance preferences on a 1–4 scale (1 = very bad, 4 = very good); democratic assessments on a 1–10 scale; corruption perceptions on a 1–4 scale (1 = hardly anyone, 4 = almost everyone); and media and political interest items on a 1–4 scale (1 = none, 4 = a great deal). Internet news frequency is harmonized to a 1–6 scale (1 = never, 6 = daily or more) across waves with differing original response categories; see the dedicated footnote in the Wave 3 discussion for details. Witnessed corruption is reported as a binary proportion. Voter turnout is self-reported and expressed as a percentage.

[14]Direct contact with elected officials and civil servants uses a broadly-worded ‘at any level’ framing in Wave 2 that differs from the narrower, problem-motivated framing in Wave 3 and from the Wave 4 and 6 formulations; these items are not used for cross-wave comparisons involving Wave 2 but are reported in the four-wave tables with appropriate documentation.

Table 3. Wave 2 (2008) Baseline: Political Orientations in Cambodia

Variable	W2 (2008)	Variable	W2 (2008)
Political Participation		*Democratic Orientations*	
Contacted elected official	32.6% (29.7–35.6)	Democratic present (0–10)	6.72 (6.47–6.96)
Contacted civil servant	31.8% (29.0–34.8)	Democratic future (0–10)	—
Contacted influential person	43.0% (39.9–46.2)	Democratic past (0–10)	—
Signed petition	—		
Attended demonstration	—	*Corruption*	
Contacted media	—	Witnessed corruption	27.7% (24.9–30.6)
Community leader (1–5 mean)	1.53 (1.49–1.57)	Nat'l govt corruption (1–4)	2.86 (2.81–2.92)
Voted in last election	—	Local govt corruption (1–4)	2.56 (2.51–2.61)
Authoritarian Preferences (1–4)		*Media & Political Interest*	
Expert rule	—	Follows political news	—
Single-party rule	1.79 (1.72–1.87)	Internet news (1–6)	—
Strongman rule	1.60 (1.54–1.67)	Political interest (1–4)	2.56 (2.50–2.62)
Military rule	2.19 (2.11–2.27)	Discusses politics (1–3)	1.65 (1.61–1.69)

Note: 95% CI in parentheses (Wilson interval for proportions; t-based for means).—= not fielded in Wave 2. $N = 1{,}000$.

The authoritarian attitude measures are telling. Single-party rule was rated at 1.79 on a four-point scale, strongman rule at 1.6, and military rule at 2.19—not numbers of a population that embraces authoritarianism as an ideal, but of one that has learned to live within it. On the forced-choice democracy preference, 61.2 percent selected "democracy is always preferable" while 30.5 percent chose "it doesn't matter"—a plurality endorsement without intensity. Cambodia in 2008 was a country in political equilibrium. No dramatic spikes, no anomalous values, no signs of the upheaval to come. The question that the next four years would pose, with startling force, was what would happen when that arrangement was briefly and dramatically disrupted.

The Awakening: Cambodia in 2012

Something extraordinary happened in Cambodia between 2008 and 2012, and the Wave 3 Asian Barometer data capture its imprint with unusual clarity.[15]

Across nearly every measure of civic engagement and political aspiration, Cambodian respondents in 2012 registered at or near the highest values in the dataset's history. Contact with influential persons rose from 43 percent in 2008 to 52.6 percent. Community leader contact averaged 1.9 on a five-point frequency scale, up from 1.53. The political activities newly tracked in Wave 3—attending demonstrations (2.6 percent ever) and signing petitions (10.5 percent ever)—debuted at levels consistent with a population in active political motion.

The catalyst was the formation of the Cambodia National Rescue Party in 2012, a merger of the Sam Rainsy Party and the Human Rights Party. The CNRP unified the fragmented non-CPP political space into a single, credible alternative with a coherent message of democratic reform, anti-corruption, and economic justice, drawing its energy from an urban youth demographic—the first generation born after the Khmer Rouge, connected to the wider world through social media, and impatient with the political settlement their parents had accepted. The July 2013 national election became the most competitive in Cambodia's post-UNTAC history. The CNRP won 55 of 123 National Assembly seats; allegations of electoral fraud triggered months of mass protest. For observers and participants alike, the political settlement that had governed Cambodia since the late 1990s appeared to be unraveling (Strangio 2014; Morgenbesser 2017; Norén-Nilsson 2021).

[15] Unless otherwise noted, the political chronology and electoral data in this section draw on Un (2013b); Um (2014); Strangio (2014); and Norén-Nilsson (2015) On the 2013 election results specifically, see COMFREL (The Committee for Free and Fair Elections in Cambodia) (2013)

The democratic expectations data tell the same story from a different angle. Cambodian respondents in 2012 produced a mean of 9.58 on the ten-point democratic future scale—near-universal optimism, suggesting a population that had collectively decided democratic change was not merely desirable but imminent. The past-present-future structure (low past: 3.97; middling present: 5.85; exceptionally high future: 9.58) is not the signature of a population evaluating its institutions on the basis of lived experience—it is a hope-driven orientation, grounded in expectation rather than experience, and therefore extraordinarily sensitive to political events. The 2012 moment was not a peak of abstract democratic commitment: the forced-choice democracy preference (56.9 percent choosing "always preferable") actually ran *lower* than in 2008. It was a peak of democratic *expectation* and *prioritization*. Nearly half of respondents (47.1 percent) prioritized political freedom over economic equality—a level that would not be observed again. Witnessed corruption, at 49 percent, reflected not an increase in actual corruption but a population more willing to name it, emboldened by opposition messaging and expanded civic space. Political interest (2.57) and news following (3.07) stood at the highest values in the Cambodian series.[16][17]

The 2012 data capture the approximate moment at which a population collectively updated its beliefs about what was politically possible, right before the regime demonstrated, with devastating effectiveness, that those beliefs were wrong.

[16]Traditional values measures also peaked in Wave 3—an unexpected finding given that the broader mobilization was associated with youth activism. One possibility is that the CNRP's messaging, which blended democratic aspiration with Khmer cultural conservatism, activated traditional values alongside democratic ones; another is a general intensification of expressed attitudes in the charged political environment of 2012.

[17]The ABS internet news item underwent substantial scale changes across waves (6-point in W2/W3, 8-point in W4, 9-point in W6) and has been harmonized to a common 1–6 frequency scale (1 = never, 6 = daily or more).

The Reckoning: Cambodia in 2015

The 2013 election confirmed the CNRP's mobilization power—55 seats to the CPP's 68, the narrowest margin in Cambodia's modern history—but the structural ceiling held.[18] Fraud allegations triggered mass protest; a January 2014 crackdown and subsequent compromise coaxed the CNRP into parliament under a fragile "Culture of Dialogue" that was less a genuine opening than a controlled decompression: the CPP retained the security forces, the judiciary, and the National Election Committee while progressively constraining the CNRP through legal harassment and restrictions on assembly (Morgenbesser 2017; Norén-Nilsson 2019). By 2015 the dialogue had stalled, and the Wave 4 survey entered the field in an atmosphere that had shifted from the hopeful energy of 2013 to something more wary.

The Wave 4 data capture a population no longer at the peak of mobilization but not yet in the trough of withdrawal. Contact with influential persons held essentially steady at 55.9 percent (the 3.3-point increase from Wave 3 is not statistically significant; $p = 0.11$), and demonstration attendance, petition-signing, and civil servant contact all edged slightly upward. The "selective retreat" of 2015 is not written primarily in the behavioral data. It is written in the attitudinal record (see Figure 3; Figure 4).

[18] Unless otherwise noted, the political chronology in this section draws on Chheang (2015); Morgenbesser (2017); and Norén-Nilsson (2019)

Table 4. Selective Retreat, 2012–2015: Wave 3 to Wave 4 Comparison

Variable	W3	W4	Δ	Variable	W3	W4	Δ
Political Participation				*Democratic Expectations (0–10)*			
Contacted elected off.	4.1%	4.5%	+0.4	Dem. future	9.58	7.72	−1.86
Contacted civil servant	6.6%	11.0%	+4.4	Dem. past	3.97	3.87	−0.10
Contacted influential	52.6%	55.9%	+3.3	Dem. present	5.85	5.06	−0.80
Signed petition	10.5%	14.5%	+4.0				
Attended demonstration	2.6%	4.5%	+2.0	*Corruption*			
Contacted media	3.2%	3.4%	+0.2	Witnessed corruption	49.4%	62.8%	+13.4
Community leader (1–5)	1.90	2.00	+0.10	Nat'l govt (1–4)	2.67	2.90	+0.23
Voted in last election	78.7%	83.2%	+4.5	Local govt (1–4)	2.47	2.56	+0.09
Authoritarian Preferences (1–4)				*Media & Political Interest*			
Expert rule	1.58	1.66	+0.08	Follows pol. news	3.07	2.86	−0.21
Single-party rule	1.97	1.78	−0.19	Internet news (1–6)	1.22	1.82	+0.61
Strongman rule	1.73	1.76	+0.03	Political interest (1–4)	2.57	2.29	−0.28
Military rule	2.19	1.98	−0.21	Discusses politics (1–3)	1.45	1.47	+0.02

Note: Point estimates only; 95% CIs reported in Table 3 and Appendix. Δ = W4 − W3. Participation rows report gate proportions (%); all other rows report wave means. Δ for proportions in percentage points; for means in scale units. N: W3 = 1,200; W4 = 1,200.

Table 4 shows the W3→W4 shifts. The attitudinal retreat is not accompanied by a corresponding rise in authoritarian acceptance—single-party rule dipped, military rule fell, and all four measures remained below 2.0. The 2015 demobilization was driven by disillusionment and tactical withdrawal, not reorientation toward authoritarian preferences.

The democratic orientation data reveal the first signs of a decoupling that would define the Cambodian trajectory. Abstract democratic commitment paradoxically surged: 74.9 percent selected "democracy is always preferable"—the highest proportion across all four waves, up from 56.9 percent in 2012. The crackdown of 2013–2014 had made the ideal visible and contested, and citizens chose sides. But prioritization began its descent simultaneously: the pro-political-freedom share of the

democracy-versus-equality trade-off contracted from 47.1 to 34.6 percent (mean: 2.91 $\rightarrow$ 2.58, $p < 0.001$). Citizens were affirming the ideal while becoming less willing to bear its costs. Democratic future expectations fell nearly two points ($p < 0.001$); democracy satisfaction dropped to 2.71—its lowest value—as the gap between elevated expectations and deteriorating reality widened. That gap would close by 2021, producing the satisfaction paradox documented in Figure 5.

Witnessed corruption surged to 63 percent—its dataset peak. The post-2013 period, with its institutional jockeying and expanded CNRP parliamentary presence, created more visible sites of corruption, not more corruption per se. Political interest and news following registered modest declines, the leading edge of a trend that would deepen sharply. The 2015 wave is the hinge: democratic hope falling but not yet crashed, behavior intact but attitudes already retreating, authoritarian acceptance still low. Unstable equilibrium, poised between the aspiration of 2012 and the normalization that was about to descend.

The Silence: Cambodia in 2021

On November 16, 2017, the Supreme Court of Cambodia dissolved the Cambodia National Rescue Party, citing a vaguely defined conspiracy to overthrow the government; 118 CNRP officials were banned from political activity, and the party's seats redistributed to CPP-aligned formations.[19] Kem Sokha had already been arrested in September; Sam Rainsy remained in exile. The dissolution did not occur in isolation. Within weeks, the *Cambodia Daily* was forced to close after receiving a disputed $6.3 million tax bill; Radio Free Asia's Cambodian bureau was shuttered; independent radio stations were pressured into pro-government programming; and civil

[19] Unless otherwise noted, the political chronology in this section draws on Un and Luo (2020); Chheang (2021); and Morgenbesser and Pepinsky (2019)

society organizations faced intensified scrutiny under the 2015 LANGO law (Norén-Nilsson 2021; Norén-Nilsson and Eng 2020). The July 2018 election, conducted without the CNRP, produced a CPP sweep of all 125 National Assembly seats—completing the transition, in Levitsky and Way's typology, from competitive to hegemonic authoritarianism (Levitsky and Way 2010; Schedler 2002).

The Wave 6 data from 2021 record the consequences.

The participation data from 2021 present a more differentiated picture than a simple collapse narrative would suggest (see Figure 3). Contact with influential persons—the item most directly measuring independent civic engagement—fell sharply, from 55.9 percent in 2015 to 23.3 percent ($p < 0.001$), a 33 percentage-point decline that represents one of the steepest single-item shifts in the dataset. Community leader contact fell to a mean of 1.39 on the frequency scale, and political discussion dropped to 1.26 on a four-point scale—a population that had largely stopped talking about politics with one another. Demonstration attendance held near its 2015 level at 3.3 percent.

What complicates any uniform "participation collapse" characterization is that several formal channel indicators actually rose substantially by 2021: petition-signing reached 30.5 percent, civil servant contact climbed to 37.2 percent, and media contact rose to 12.2 percent. These increases likely reflect the rapid expansion of internet access enabling digital petitions and online contact, combined with the transformation of formal institutional channels into vehicles for routine patronage interaction under a now-uncontested regime. The divergence is itself evidence of demobilization by subtraction—but it also preserves a degree of citizen agency within the normalization framework. In an environment where opposition parties, independent media, and civil society organizations have been dismantled, citizens learn which levers still function and redirect their

efforts accordingly. The result is engagement that is simultaneously rational at the individual level and depoliticizing at the collective level: participation through officially sanctioned channels rises precisely as independent civic action collapses.

Table 5. Four-Wave Trajectory of Political Orientations in Cambodia, 2008–2021

Variable	W2 (2008)	W3 (2012)	W4 (2015)	**W6 (2021)**	Δ W3→W6	Δ W4→W6
Political Participation						
Contacted elected official	32.6% (29.7–35.6)	4.1% (3.1–5.4)	4.5% (3.4–5.9)	**13.3% (11.4–15.5)**	+9.2 pp	+8.8 pp
Contacted civil servant	31.8% (29.0–34.8)	6.6% (5.3–8.2)	11.0% (9.3–12.9)	**37.2% (34.4–40.1)**	+30.6 pp	+26.2 pp
Contacted influential person	43.0% (39.9–46.2)	52.6% (49.7–55.5)	55.9% (53.1–58.7)	**23.3% (20.9–25.9)**	-29.3 pp	-32.6 pp
Signed petition	—	10.5% (8.9–12.4)	14.5% (12.6–16.6)	**30.5% (27.9–33.4)**	+20.0 pp	+16.1 pp
Attended demonstration	—	2.6% (1.8–3.7)	4.5% (3.5–5.9)	**3.3% (2.3–4.6)**	+0.7 pp	-1.2 pp
Contacted media	—	3.2% (2.3–4.4)	3.4% (2.4–4.6)	**12.2% (10.3–14.2)**	+9.0 pp	+8.8 pp
Contacted community leader (mean, 1–5)	1.53 (1.49–1.57)	1.90 (1.85–1.96)	2.00 (1.95–2.06)	**1.39 (1.34–1.43)**	-0.52	-0.62
Voted in last election	—	78.7% (76.2–80.9)	83.2% (80.9–85.2)	**88.1% (86.1–89.9)**	+9.4 pp	+4.9 pp
Authoritarian Preferences (1–4: very bad to very good)						
Expert rule	—	1.58 (1.53–1.63)	1.66 (1.62–1.70)	**2.11 (2.06–2.16)**	+0.53	+0.45
Single-party rule	1.79 (1.72–1.87)	1.97 (1.91–2.03)	1.78 (1.73–1.83)	**2.21 (2.15–2.26)**	+0.24	+0.43
Strongman rule	1.60 (1.54–1.67)	1.73 (1.67–1.78)	1.76 (1.71–1.81)	**2.17 (2.12–2.23)**	+0.45	+0.42
Military rule	2.19 (2.11–2.27)	2.19 (2.12–2.25)	1.98 (1.93–2.04)	**2.21 (2.15–2.27)**	+0.02	+0.23
Democratic Commitment & Satisfaction						
Democracy always preferable (%)	61.2% (57.8–64.4)	56.9% (54.0–59.7)	74.9% (72.4–77.4)	**66.5% (63.6–69.3)**	+9.7 pp	NA
Dem. best form of govt (1–4)	—	3.26 (3.22–3.29)	3.15 (3.12–3.19)	**3.20 (3.16–3.23)**	-0.06	NA
Democracy vs. equality (1–5)	—	2.91 (2.83–3.00)	2.58 (2.49–2.67)	**2.31 (2.23–2.39)**	-0.60	NA
Democracy satisfaction (1–4)	2.97 (2.92–3.01)	2.98 (2.94–3.02)	2.71 (2.66–2.75)	**3.10 (3.07–3.14)**	+0.12	NA
Democratic Expectations (0–10 scale)						
Democratic future (10pt)	—	9.58 (9.48–9.68)	7.72 (7.48–7.96)	**6.67 (6.45–6.89)**	-2.91	-1.05
Democratic past (10pt)	—	3.97 (3.85–4.09)	3.87 (3.75–3.98)	**4.78 (4.65–4.92)**	+0.82	+0.92
Democratic present (10pt)	6.72 (6.47–6.96)	5.85 (5.66–6.04)	5.06 (4.89–5.23)	**5.77 (5.62–5.92)**	-0.08	+0.72
Corruption						
Witnessed corruption (binary)	27.7% (24.9–30.6)	49.4% (46.5–52.3)	62.8% (59.9–65.7)	**14.9% (12.9–17.1)**	-34.5 pp	-47.9 pp
National govt corruption (1–4)	2.86 (2.81–2.92)	2.67 (2.62–2.72)	2.90 (2.86–2.94)	**2.33 (2.29–2.37)**	-0.34	-0.57
Local govt corruption (1–4)	2.56 (2.51–2.61)	2.47 (2.42–2.52)	2.56 (2.52–2.61)	**2.36 (2.32–2.41)**	-0.11	-0.20
Media & Political Interest						
Follows political news	—	3.07 (2.99–3.14)	2.86 (2.78–2.94)	**2.04 (1.97–2.11)**	-1.03	-0.82
Internet news (1–6)	—	1.22 (1.16–1.27)	1.82 (1.72–1.92)	**4.66 (4.54–4.78)**	+3.45	+2.84
Political interest	2.56 (2.50–2.62)	2.57 (2.52–2.62)	2.29 (2.24–2.34)	**2.06 (2.01–2.11)**	-0.51	-0.23
Discusses politics	1.65 (1.61–1.69)	1.45 (1.42–1.49)	1.47 (1.44–1.50)	**1.26 (1.23–1.28)**	-0.20	-0.21

Note: N per wave: W2 = 1,000; W3 = 1,200; W4 = 1,200; W6 = 1,242. Rows 1–6 (Political Participation) report the percentage of respondents who ever engaged in each activity (gate proportion), with 95% CI (Wilson interval) in parentheses; Δ for these rows is in percentage points. Democracy always preferable reports the percentage selecting 'democracy is always preferable' (Wilson CI). Remaining rows report unweighted wave means with 95% CI (t-based) in parentheses; Δ is the arithmetic difference. '—' or 'textemdash' indicates variable not fielded in that wave. Δ W3→W6 = peak-to-trough change (W6 minus W3). Δ W4→W6 = post-dissolution change (W6 minus W4). W6 column in bold marks the endpoint of the trajectory. Voted last election and corruption witnessed are binary proportions.

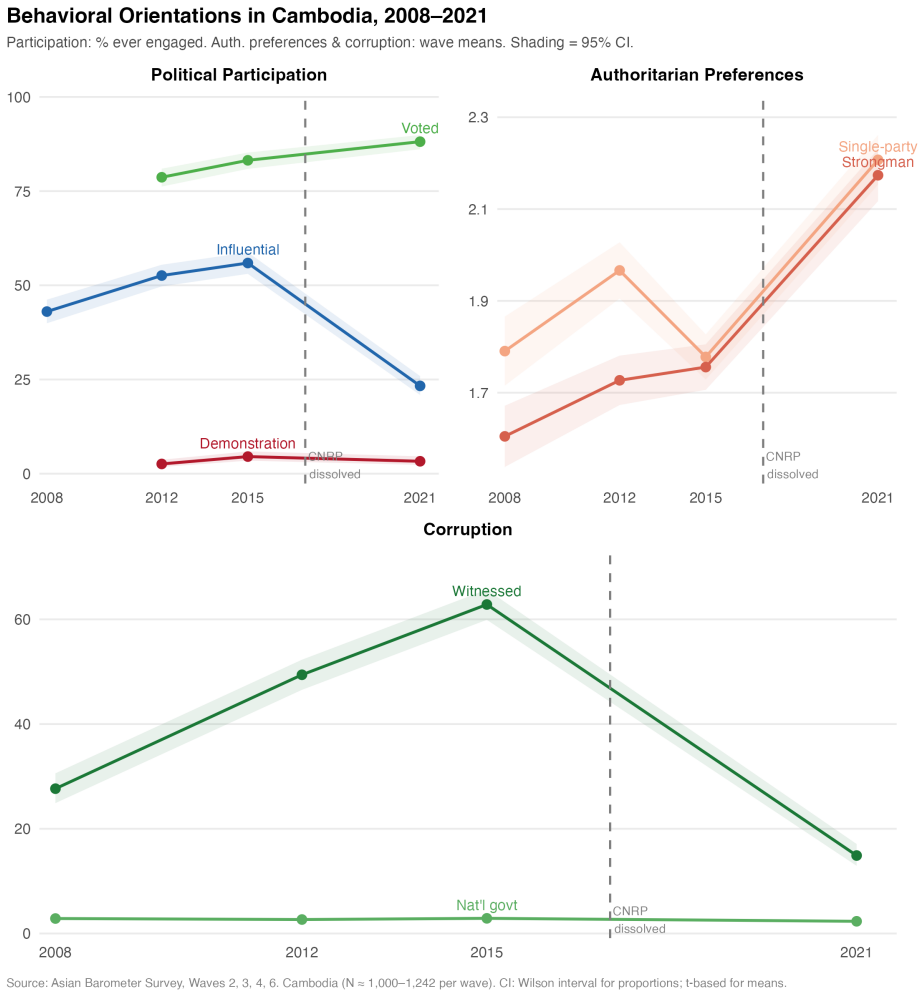

Figure 3. Behavioral Orientations in Cambodia, 2008–2021. Point estimates with 95% confidence intervals (Wilson intervals for proportions; t-based for means). Dashed vertical line marks the 2017 CNRP dissolution. Participation panel reports gate proportions (% ever engaged); authoritarian preferences and corruption panels report wave means on original scales. Source: Asian Barometer Survey, Waves 2, 3, 4, 6.

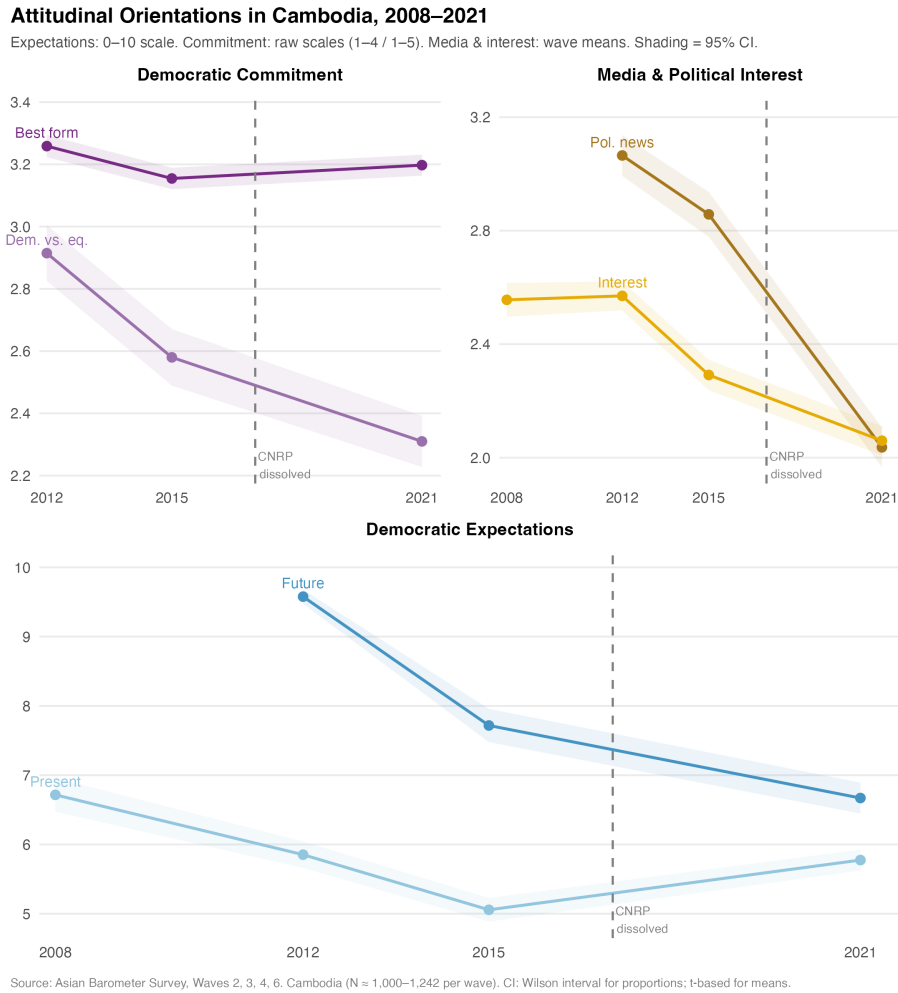

Figure 4. Attitudinal Orientations in Cambodia, 2008–2021. Point estimates with 95% confidence intervals (t-based for means). Dashed vertical line marks the 2017 CNRP dissolution. Democratic Expectations panel: 0–10 scale. Democratic Commitment panel: dem_best_form (1–4 mean) and dem_vs_equality (1–5 mean), showing stable abstract commitment diverging from declining expectations. Media & Political Interest panel: wave means on original scales. Source: Asian Barometer Survey, Waves 2, 3, 4, 6.

Democratic Orientations in 2021

The democratic orientation data from Wave 6 complete the divergence pattern that first appeared in 2015, now with the full force of the post-dissolution political closure behind it (see Figure 4).

Abstract democratic commitment, remarkably, survived the dissolution largely intact. “Democracy may have its problems but it is still the best form of government” registered a mean of 3.20 in Wave 6—between “agree” and “strongly agree,” statistically indistinguishable from its Wave 4 value (3.15; $p = 0.080$) and only marginally below the Wave 3 peak of 3.26 ($p = 0.014$). The stability of this item across a period in which every other democratic indicator declined sharply is among the most important findings in the dataset. Cambodians in 2021 continued to endorse democracy as an ideal at rates essentially unchanged from the peak mobilization of 2012. Whatever the dissolution accomplished, it did not produce ideological conversion.

The forced-choice democracy preference declined from its Wave 4 peak of 74.9 percent to 66.5 percent—still a clear majority. The critical diagnostic is where the movement went: the “doesn’t matter” category continued to decline to 17.5 percent, its lowest level across all four waves, while “authoritarian government can sometimes be preferable” more than doubled from 6.1 to 16.0 percent. This distribution is inconsistent with generalized apathy and inconsistent with fear-driven acquiescence; it is consistent with a specific pragmatic recalculation by citizens who reassessed their democratic commitment in light of a political reality in which the democratic alternative no longer existed.

Democratic prioritization reached its lowest recorded level. The pro-political-freedom share of the democracy-versus-equality trade-off contracted from 47.1 percent in 2012 to 21.7 percent in 2021—a collapse of more than half. The “both equally important” midpoint expanded from 2.5 to 15.1 percent, while “authoritarian sometimes preferable” grew modestly. The citizens most susceptible to deprioritization were those whose commitment to political freedom had been moderate and

conditional—the pragmatic middle that the normalization framework predicts would be most responsive to the closure of democratic possibility.

The democratic expectation items continued their descent, though the 63 percent nonresponse on the democratic future item and 43 percent on the democratic present mean these estimates describe only the minority of respondents who retained enough political engagement to formulate a numerical judgment. Treated as supporting evidence rather than independent findings, the democratic future rating fell from 7.72 in 2015 to 6.67 in 2021 ($p < 0.001$)—a drop of nearly three points from the extraordinary 9.58 recorded in 2012.

The most robust single finding from the Wave 6 democratic orientation battery is the satisfaction paradox (Linde and Ekman 2003; Valgarðsson and Devine 2022): democracy satisfaction rose to 3.10—its highest value across all four waves, on an item with only 6.4 percent nonresponse—in the least democratic moment in the country's modern history. Figure 5 shows why. Satisfaction is a function of the gap between expectations and perceived reality; by 2021 that gap had closed from below, as expectations collapsed while the regime delivered stability through its patronage infrastructure. The satisfaction recovery is the clearest single indicator of adaptive preference formation in the dataset.

The authoritarian acceptance measures moved in mirror image. All four alternative governance indicators rose to their highest levels: expert rule to 2.11, single-party rule to 2.21, strongman rule to 2.17, and military rule to 2.21. The jump was concentrated entirely in the W4-to-W6 period—the six years that encompassed the CNRP's destruction and the subsequent one-party election. What had been stable or declining through 2015 now surged.

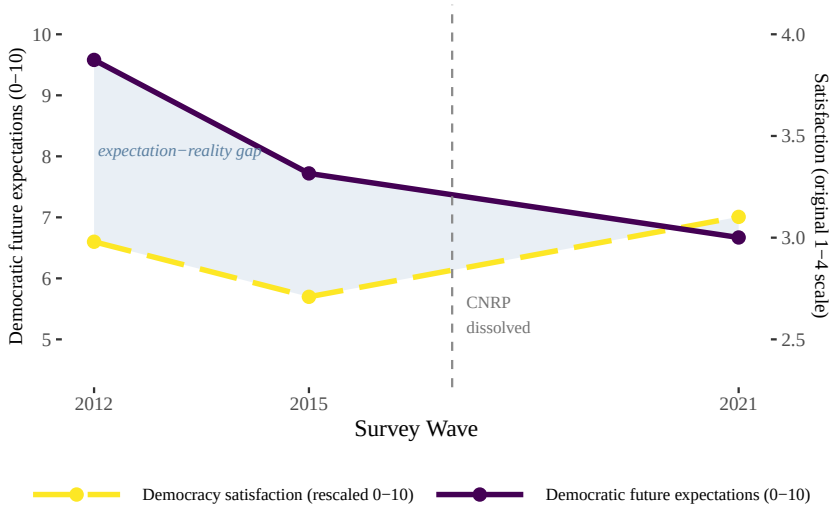

Figure 5. The satisfaction paradox, 2012–2021. Democratic future expectations (0–10 scale) and democracy satisfaction rescaled to the same range (original 1–4 scale shown on right axis). Shaded region marks the expectation–reality gap. The gap closes by 2021 as expectations collapse while satisfaction rises—the empirical signature of authoritarian normalization. Dashed vertical line marks the 2017 CNRP dissolution. Source: Asian Barometer Survey, Waves 3, 4, 6.

The authoritarian acceptance measures remain around 2.2 on a four-point scale—below the midpoint. Cambodians are not rating authoritarianism as "good"; they are rating it as slightly less bad than before. The timing—concentrated after the removal of the democratic alternative, not during earlier repressive tightening—points toward adaptive preference formation rather than genuine conversion. This is not a population that has found a new political faith. It is a population that has stopped believing the old one was achievable.

The article proposes the term authoritarian normalization to describe this process, distinguishing it from authoritarian legitimation. Legitimation implies that citizens have come to view the regime as rightfully entitled to rule—on the basis of performance, ideology, or tradition; normalization implies something weaker but potentially more durable: citizens have

adjusted their expressed preferences to align with the only available reality. The vulnerabilities differ accordingly. A regime sustained by legitimation is threatened when performance falters; one sustained by normalization is threatened when alternatives re-enter the political imagination.

The Cambodian pattern is not performative compliance in Wedeen's sense, where citizens maintain private skepticism while publicly enacting belief (Wedeen 1998). Survey responses are private, and the attitudinal shifts reflect genuine reorientation: citizens moved into conditional authoritarianism rather than noncommittal safe responses, and the shifts cut uniformly across demographic subgroups. The democracy-versus-equality trajectory—from near-parity in 2012 to a two-to-one margin favoring equality by 2021—bears the hallmarks of Elster's adaptive preference formation (Elster 2016, orig. 1983; Przeworski 2022), but the adaptation is partial. Abstract endorsement of democracy proved resilient while the willingness to prioritize it collapsed. A regime that eliminates alternatives need not change what citizens believe in principle; it need only wait for the practical implications of those beliefs to atrophy (Jones and Cowan 2025).

The corruption data offer perhaps the most unsettling evidence of normalization. Witnessed corruption collapsed from 63 percent in 2015 to 15 percent in 2021. Perceived national government corruption also declined, from 2.9 to 2.33 on the four-point scale. On the surface, these numbers might suggest genuine anti-corruption progress. The CPP did conduct selective anti-corruption campaigns during this period, targeting rivals and politically inconvenient officials. But the magnitude of the witnessed-corruption decline—from nearly two-thirds to one-seventh of the population—is too large to explain through policy alone.

The more parsimonious explanation is that the corruption decline reflects the same demobilization process visible in the participation data. When

citizens withdraw from political life—when they stop contacting officials, stop attending meetings, stop engaging with governance institutions—they also reduce their exposure to the sites where corruption is experienced and observed. A population that does not petition, does not demonstrate, and does not contact civil servants is also a population that has fewer occasions to witness a bribe demanded or a favor exchanged. Demobilization, in this reading, does not merely reduce political action; it reduces the perceptual evidence that political action might address. The regime becomes less corrupt not because it has reformed but because citizens have stopped looking.

External assessments corroborate this interpretation: Cambodia's Transparency International CPI score moved from 21 to 23 over the study period, registering no meaningful improvement even as survey-reported witnessing of corruption collapsed fourfold (Transparency International 2023). An alternative and not mutually exclusive explanation invokes the survey environment itself: in a political climate where the opposition has been criminalized, respondents may calculate that acknowledging witnessed corruption carries risks, and the social desirability bias literature confirms that such effects intensify under political constraint (Schedler and Sarsfield 2007; Frye et al. 2017). The two mechanisms—reduced exposure through demobilization and increased reticence through social desirability pressure—likely operate in tandem.

The voter turnout paradox completes the portrait. Self-reported voting rose from 79 percent in 2012 to 88 percent in 2021, even as all other forms of political engagement collapsed. The 2018 election made the ritual character of Cambodian voting unusually visible: the CNRP-in-exile's "clean finger" campaign transformed polling-station ink from an anti-fraud measure into a tool of social surveillance, with factory workers warned of wage deductions for returning without inked fingers (McCargo 2018).

Voting in a one-party election is not a political act in the same sense as voting in a competitive one; it is a demonstration of compliance. The fact that turnout rises precisely as meaningful engagement collapses suggests that Cambodians understand the distinction even as they perform the ritual.[20]

Political news following fell to 2.04, political interest to 2.06, and political discussion to 1.26—the lowest values across all four waves. The internet news variable throws this withdrawal into sharp relief: harmonized consumption rose to 4.66 by Wave 6, reflecting rapid expansion of internet infrastructure. Cambodians in 2021 had far greater access to online information than at any previous wave, yet their political interest and news following fell to historic lows. The infrastructure for engagement had expanded; the will to use it for political purposes had collapsed. Demobilization, once initiated through the removal of the political alternative, generates its own sustaining momentum through this informational feedback loop.

The Cambodia of 2021 is, in a sense, the inverse of the Cambodia of 2012. Where the earlier moment was characterized by activation across all dimensions—participation, aspiration, attention, even the willingness to name corruption—the later moment is characterized by withdrawal across all the same dimensions. The symmetry is striking and, for the theoretical

[20]The international orientation data add a final dimension to the normalization portrait. Cambodian assessments of Chinese influence in the region grew more positive between Waves 4 and 6, rising from 2.69 to 2.88 on a four-point scale measuring perceived benefit versus harm. More striking still, expectations of future Asian—implicitly Chinese—regional influence climbed from 2.74 in Wave 4 to 3.3 in Wave 6, a trajectory that places Cambodia among the most China-positive publics in the ABS dataset. This is consistent with Cambodia's deepening alignment with Beijing during this period, visible in Belt and Road infrastructure investment, the Ream Naval Base controversy, and Cambodia's consistent support for Chinese positions within ASEAN. But it also fits the normalization logic: as democratic futures recede and Western-aligned political alternatives are eliminated, alignment with the ascendant authoritarian power in the region becomes the natural orientation of a population adjusting to the available political reality. A paired comparison with Vietnam or the Philippines—where territorial disputes drive China perceptions in sharply negative directions despite similar economic interdependence—would sharpen this point considerably (Strangio 2020).

argument, essential. It suggests that what changed between the two moments was not any single attitude or behavior but the underlying orientation from which attitudes and behaviors derive—what might be called the perceived horizon of political possibility. When that horizon expanded, everything expanded with it. When it contracted, everything contracted.

Alternative Mechanisms and Adjudication

The preceding narrative has interpreted the synchronized attitudinal and behavioral shifts across ABS waves as evidence of demobilization by subtraction. Before drawing theoretical implications, it is necessary to adjudicate this interpretation against four competing explanations: preference falsification under intensified repression, pandemic-era behavioral disruption, technological channel substitution, and generational replacement. Each generates distinct observable predictions that can be evaluated against the available data.

Preference falsification. The most direct challenge holds that the observed shifts reflect increased survey reticence under harsher post-2017 conditions rather than genuine attitude change. Item nonresponse on democratic expectations rose substantially—from 24 to 63 percent on the democratic future item—consistent with an environment in which some respondents feel uncomfortable evaluating their country's democratic trajectory.[21]

Three considerations limit the scope of this alternative. First, if survey reticence were the primary driver, it should manifest broadly—but straightlining rates on the authoritarian preferences battery actually *declined* from Wave 4 (38 percent) to Wave 6 (35 percent), and acquiescence rates remained low and stable. Second, the demobilization

[21] Mean nonresponse across all political items rose from approximately 5 percent in Wave 3 to 14 percent in Wave 6, consistent with either increased reluctance or decreased political engagement.

pattern began before the most intensive period of political closure: democratic future expectations fell nearly two points between Waves 3 and 4, and political interest declined, well before the CNRP dissolution. Third, non-political placebo items—national pride, family economic situation, perceived economic change—show no systematic decline across waves; generalized reticence would be expected to suppress these as well.

The most direct empirical test draws on ABS items measuring perceived freedom of speech and freedom to organize. Adding both as covariates in OLS models predicting democratic future expectations, satisfaction, and preference produces virtually no attenuation: the Wave 6 coefficient on democratic future expectations changes by 0.4 percent. The moderation pattern runs opposite to the preference-falsification prediction: declines in democratic future expectations are concentrated among respondents who perceive *more* freedom of speech, not less (Wave 4 interaction: $\beta = -1.88$, $p < .001$; Wave 6: $\beta = -1.18$, $p < .001$). The deepest disillusionment runs through precisely those who feel most free to express it—a pattern consistent with genuine preference revision rather than strategic concealment.

The nonresponse gradient across the democratic orientation battery is itself analytically informative. Items with the lowest nonresponse—the forced-choice democracy preference (13.4 percent), the democracy–equality trade-off (8.1 percent)—are those requiring respondents to select among pre-defined positions. Items with the highest nonresponse—democratic future (63 percent), democratic present (42.5 percent)—require generating a numerical judgment about Cambodia's democratic trajectory. Citizens can still answer whether democracy is desirable in the abstract, but increasingly decline to evaluate where their country sits on a democratic continuum. The 63 percent who did not answer the democratic future item and the 37 percent who answered with

diminished expectations are complementary expressions of the same process.

Partisan Heterogeneity and the Scope of Demobilization

If subtraction operates through removal of the opposition specifically, attitudinal shifts should concentrate among former CNRP supporters, who lost their vehicle for political expression, rather than among CPP supporters, whose political home remained intact. The ABS vote choice items permit a direct test.

The partisan distribution across waves is itself the first piece of evidence. In Wave 4 (2015), CNRP voters constituted 21.3 percent of the sample and CPP voters 50.8 percent, with 17.2 percent nonvoters and 7.2 percent declining to answer. By Wave 6 (2021), the CNRP share had collapsed to 2.7 percent—34 respondents, a residual so small it is analytically uninformative except as a marker of the dissolution's completeness. The CPP share returned to 60.1 percent, absorbing an unknown proportion of former CNRP supporters who reported voting CPP in the uncontested 2018 election. The DK/Refuse category nearly tripled, from 7.2 to 18.8 percent. The redistribution of the CNRP's former constituency—into CPP voting, nonvoting, or refusal to answer—*is* the subtraction documented at the level of individual survey responses.

The W4-to-W6 decomposition of key outcomes by partisan group yields a finding that initially appears to cut against the subtraction-specific mechanism: the shifts are broadly uniform. Contact with influential persons—the clearest measure of independent civic engagement—dropped by approximately 30 percentage points across all groups: 35.1 points among CPP voters, 30.9 among CNRP voters, 29.9 among nonvoters, and 25.6 among those declining to answer. Democratic future expectations declined by 1.27 to 1.39 points across groups. Single-party rule acceptance

rose by 0.29 to 0.47 points. The absence of partisan heterogeneity is robust: no group was spared the demobilization, and no group experienced it with distinctive severity.

Two considerations complicate the interpretation of this uniformity as evidence against the subtraction mechanism. The first is methodological. The W6 partisan categories are themselves *products* of the dissolution. The 746 respondents classified as "CPP voters" in Wave 6 include an unknown number of former CNRP sympathizers who voted CPP in a one-party election—citizens for whom "CPP voter" is a post-dissolution category imposed by the absence of alternatives rather than a stable partisan identity. The DK/Refuse category, which tripled to 18.8 percent, likely contains the most resistant former CNRP supporters—those who could neither bring themselves to report voting CPP nor risk identifying with a criminalized party. Their democratic orientation profile in Wave 6 is consistent with this reading: they registered the lowest proportion selecting "democracy always preferable" (61.1 percent) and the highest rate of conditional authoritarianism (18.1 percent) of any group—a pattern more consistent with suppressed democratic preferences under duress than with genuine authoritarian conversion. The dissolution did not merely change attitudes; it destroyed the partisan categories through which differential effects could be measured.

The second consideration is theoretical. The prediction that CNRP supporters should be differentially affected assumes subtraction operates like losing one's team. The framework advanced here operates at a different level: the removal of the credible alternative restructures the political field itself, not merely the partisan calculus of opposition supporters. CPP voters in 2015 inhabited a competitive system in which political information served a decision-making function and contacting persons outside the party apparatus had strategic rationale; CPP voters in

2021 inhabited a one-party state in which neither condition obtained. The uniformity of the observed shifts is precisely what a field-level mechanism predicts—and what a party-level mechanism does not.

Supplementary Evidence from the 2017 Socio-Economic Survey

The 2017 Cambodia Socio-Economic Survey provides a second-instrument snapshot of civic orientations in the final months before the CNRP dissolution, partially addressing the temporal gap between ABS Waves 4 (2015) and 6 (2021). The SES data are not directly comparable to the ABS in scale or design, but the directional evidence is informative.

In early-to-mid 2017, 86.1 percent of SES respondents reported freedom to speak without fear, 87.9 percent reported freedom to join organizations without fear, and 94.0 percent reported freedom to vote for any party without fear—near-universal agreement, recorded in the final months before the elimination of the only meaningful alternative party. The political closure that followed was not acting on a population that already felt constrained. These figures establish the subjective distance between the pre-dissolution civic environment and the post-dissolution environment documented in Wave 6.

The SES tea money item corroborates the corruption trajectory from a more behaviorally concrete instrument: 34.9 percent of respondents reported paying additional money to officials in 2016 to get things done. This direct bribery measure confirms that petty corruption remained widespread in the immediate pre-dissolution period. With the ABS witnessed-corruption item registering 63 percent in 2015 and 15 percent in 2021, the SES rate of 34.9 percent for 2016 falls precisely between these values on a narrower measure, making it more difficult to attribute the subsequent ABS collapse to genuine anti-corruption progress.

Satisfaction with local governance was high: 88.2 percent agreed that commune councillors are "helpful and responsive at solving problems," and 89.4 percent agreed that the village chief "generally works for the benefit of citizens." These figures are consistent with the CPP's patronage infrastructure functioning effectively at the commune level—the same infrastructure into which, the article argues, citizens redirected their engagement after the dissolution foreclosed independent channels. The post-dissolution rise in civil servant contact (from 11 percent in Wave 4 to 37 percent in Wave 6) landed on institutional ground that citizens already found functional.

Detailed SES governance modules were not publicly released for 2018–2020; the data gap mirrors the ABS Wave 5 absence discussed above.[22]

Pandemic-era behavioral disruption. Wave 6 was collected during the COVID-19 pandemic, and public health restrictions could independently depress physical participation measures. The concern is legitimate but bounded. The key attitudinal shifts—the decline in democratic future expectations, the rise in authoritarian governance acceptance—are not plausibly explained by pandemic restrictions, which constrain behavior but have no direct mechanism for altering governance preferences. The decline in democratic expectations began in Wave 4 (2015), six years before the pandemic. Demonstration attendance held essentially constant between Wave 4 and Wave 6 (4.5 to 3.3 percent), while the sharpest participation decline occurred in contacting influential persons, an activity requiring no face-to-face contact. The pandemic may have amplified certain behavioral

[22]The only post-dissolution SES data publicly available contain a single item on satisfaction with the government's handling of COVID-19. The systematic unavailability of civic orientation data across both survey programs during the years immediately following the CNRP dissolution is itself consistent with the political closure documented here.

measures; it cannot account for the pattern's breadth, direction, or temporal onset.[23]

Temporal resolution and the dissolution-as-keystone interpretation. The six-year gap between Wave 4 (2015) and Wave 6 (2021) means the analysis cannot determine whether the sharpest attitudinal changes occurred as an acute shock immediately following the dissolution, accumulated gradually through 2021, or reflect primarily the cumulative repressive apparatus that accompanied it. Elements of all three models likely operated simultaneously. Two considerations favor the subtraction-centered interpretation over the repression-centered alternative. First, the attitudinal trajectory began before the most intensive period of repression: democratic future expectations fell nearly two points and political interest declined between Waves 3 and 4, when the CNRP was under selective pressure but still functionally intact. If cumulative repression were the primary driver, onset should concentrate post-2017. Second, the domain-specificity of the shifts is more consistent with a mechanism operating through the structure of political alternatives than with generalized intimidation, which would be expected to depress expressed attitudes across domains. The dissolution is treated here as the keystone of the closure process—the act that restructured the political field—even as the accompanying repressive measures amplified and accelerated those adjustments.

The domain-specificity pattern constitutes the strongest evidence against a fear-centered interpretation. National pride, family economic assessment, and perceived economic change are all statistically stable between Wave 4

[23] One placebo item does register a notable decline: interpersonal trust fell from 14 percent (Wave 4) to 5 percent (Wave 6) on the binary "most people can be trusted" item. This drop is consistent with the social atomization documented in pandemic-era survey research across multiple countries and may also reflect broader erosion of social cohesion under intensified authoritarianism (Aassve et al. 2021). However, the fact that this is the only non-political item showing a substantial decline—while national pride, family economic assessment, and perceived economic change all remain stable—suggests a localized effect rather than a general contamination of the survey environment.

and Wave 6, while large directional shifts are concentrated in political aspiration, civic engagement, and democratic prioritization—precisely the domain the dissolution restructured. Generalized fear produces broad-spectrum attenuation (see Figure 1); the Cambodian data show selectivity. Full placebo battery results are in Appendix Table A3.

Technological channel substitution. The finding that participation through formal channels rose between Wave 4 and Wave 6—petition-signing, civil servant contact, and media contact all increased—while contact with influential persons outside the state apparatus declined, could reflect a shift in participation modalities driven by smartphone and internet penetration rather than political demobilization. If citizens simply migrated from informal, face-to-face civic engagement to digitally mediated formal channels, the resulting pattern would resemble demobilization even if total civic engagement were unchanged or increasing.

This interpretation is difficult to sustain for two reasons. First, it cannot explain the concurrent attitudinal shifts: channel substitution might redistribute participation across modes but provides no mechanism for the simultaneous decline in democratic expectations, rise in authoritarian acceptance, and collapse of political interest. If citizens were merely engaging through different channels, their attitudes toward democracy and authoritarianism should remain stable. They did not. Second, the formal channels that expanded—petitioning, contacting civil servants, contacting media—are precisely those most compatible with regime-managed participation under hegemonic authoritarianism. The rise of these channels alongside the collapse of independent engagement is more consistent with the substitution of participatory form for participatory substance than with genuine channel migration.

Generational replacement. Cambodia's young population and rapid demographic change raise the possibility that apparent attitudinal shifts

across waves reflect cohort replacement rather than within-individual attitude change: the politically activated youth of 2012 aged into their thirties by 2021, while a new cohort with no memory of the CNRP mobilization entered the survey frame. If the post-2017 shifts are concentrated among younger respondents, compositional change rather than demobilization could be driving the aggregate pattern.

The subgroup decompositions do not support this interpretation. The key shifts between Wave 4 and Wave 6 are broad-based across age groups, education levels, and urban/rural residence. Contact with influential persons declined among under-30s (51.5 to 22.5 percent), 30–49 year-olds (55.8 to 24.8 percent), and over-50s (59.9 to 21.5 percent) alike. Single-party rule acceptance rose across all three age groups. Political interest fell uniformly regardless of age, education, or urbanicity. If generational replacement were the primary mechanism, the shifts should concentrate in the youngest cohort or attenuate among older respondents who experienced the CNRP period directly; instead, the pattern is strikingly uniform. This breadth is consistent with a population-wide reorientation rather than a compositional artifact.

Taken together, the adjudication tests support the demobilization-by-subtraction interpretation while acknowledging that the 2021 data likely reflect some degree of pandemic amplification and elevated survey reticence on the most politically sensitive items. The core finding—synchronized, domain-specific shifts in political orientations that began before the pandemic, cut across all demographic subgroups, and leave non-political attitudes largely untouched—is more consistent with genuine attitudinal adjustment to political closure than with any single alternative mechanism.

Conclusion

The mechanism identified here—the restructuring of citizen orientations through the removal of political alternatives—operates wherever dominant-party regimes consolidate power. Four theoretical implications bear emphasis.

The first concerns the mechanism itself. Demobilization by subtraction does not operate by eroding democratic values. Abstract democratic commitment remained essentially stable across the Cambodian study period; a clear majority of respondents in 2021 endorsed democracy as the best form of government at rates statistically indistinguishable from 2012. What collapsed was not the ideal but the willingness to prioritize it against competing goods and, on the more tentatively measured expectation items, the perceived horizon within which the ideal could be realized. The breadth of that collapse—uniform across CPP and former CNRP voters alike—confirms that the mechanism operates at the level of the political field rather than the partisan calculus of individual supporters. CPP voters did not lose their party; they lost a political system in which independent information and outside-the-apparatus contact served any strategic purpose. The pro-political-freedom share contracted from 47 to 22 percent; democracy satisfaction paradoxically rose to its highest recorded level (Figure 5). The divergence between resilient ideals and collapsing prioritization suggests that democratic attitudes in authoritarian contexts have at least three partially independent dimensions—ideal endorsement, practical prioritization, and feasibility expectation—that respond to the structure of available political alternatives in characteristically different ways (Jones and Cowan 2025). Cross-national surveys that aggregate these dimensions into a single “democratic support” index may be measuring a composite whose components move in opposite directions under precisely the conditions of greatest theoretical interest.

The second implication concerns the relationship between hope and democratic attitudes. The Wave 3 data suggest that the extraordinary democratic optimism of 2012 was not accompanied by correspondingly extraordinary democratic commitment—the forced-choice democracy preference ran *lower* in 2012 than in 2015, when commitment surged precisely as expectations were falling. This temporal decoupling suggests that democratic support in authoritarian contexts is driven by two distinct psychological mechanisms that peak at different moments: feasibility perception, which peaked when the CNRP made democracy appear imminent; and value crystallization, which peaked when the post-2013 crackdown placed democratic values under visible siege. The Cambodian sequence—commitment lagging expectation on the upswing, then outlasting it on the downswing—challenges the foundational assumption of the political culture tradition that democratic values and democratic expectations move in tandem.[24]

The third implication concerns corruption measurement. Survey-based corruption indicators may systematically understate corruption in demobilized populations: when citizens withdraw from engagement with state institutions, they withdraw from the sites where corruption is experienced and observed. The CPP's anti-corruption efforts during this period may have had some genuine effect, but the fourfold collapse in witnessed corruption—from 49 percent to 15 percent—is more parsimoniously explained by the withdrawal of citizens from institutional encounters where corruption becomes visible. External assessments corroborate this interpretation: Cambodia's Transparency International CPI score was essentially unchanged across the study period. Instruments

[24]The canonical formulation of democratic values as a stable cultural attribute is found in the political culture tradition from Inglehart (1997) onward. The Cambodian data suggest a more situationally contingent model—closer to what Bratton and Mattes have termed "demand for democracy" as a function of perceived supply (Bratton et al. 2004; Mattes and Bratton 2007).

like the CPI may be particularly vulnerable to this dynamic in consolidating authoritarian regimes.

The fourth implication is diagnostic. The divergence between electoral participation and civic participation—turnout rising to 88 percent even as independent civic engagement collapsed—may serve as a generalizable indicator of authoritarian normalization. Where elections are maintained as regime rituals rather than competitive mechanisms, rising turnout signals not democratic health but its opposite: the transformation of voting from an act of political choice into an act of political compliance (Schedler 2002; Magaloni and Kricheli 2010). The Cambodian case suggests that this turnout-participation divergence emerges specifically in the wake of opposition elimination, and that its appearance in other contexts—wherever rising turnout coincides with collapsing civic engagement—should be read as evidence that the electoral arena has been substantively emptied even if it remains formally intact.

These findings carry inherent limitations. Four cross-sectional waves across thirteen years provide suggestive but not definitive evidence; the six-year gap between Wave 4 (2015) and Wave 6 (2021) means the analysis cannot pinpoint whether the sharpest attitudinal shifts occurred immediately following the CNRP dissolution or accumulated gradually, nor can it isolate the dissolution's contribution from the accompanying media shutdowns, civil society restrictions, and electoral manipulation. The elevated nonresponse on democratic expectation items in Wave 6—reaching 63 percent on the democratic future measure—means the attitudinal estimates from 2021 are based on the subset of respondents willing to venture an opinion. A logistic regression predicting nonresponse on the Wave 6 democratic future item finds that neither perceived freedom of speech (OR = 1.01, $p = 0.95$) nor freedom to organize (OR = 0.90, $p = 0.36$) predicts missingness. The silence is withdrawal, not suppression.

The 2021 democratic future mean is, in the strictest sense, a survivor statistic. Bounds analysis addresses the concern directly. Assigning all nonrespondents the scale maximum—the most conservative possible assumption—raises the W6 mean to 8.77, narrowing but not eliminating the decline from the 2012 peak (-0.81). Assigning nonrespondents the scale midpoint produces a W6 mean of 5.62 and a cumulative decline of -3.96 from Wave 3—comparable to the observed respondent-only estimate. Only assigning all nonrespondents a score of zero could mechanically reverse the trajectory, which requires believing the missing respondents are, without exception, deeply anti-democratic. The full bounds table is reported in Appendix Table A9. The question is not whether a decline occurred—under all plausible assumptions, it did—but how large. That 63 percent of respondents could not or would not venture an opinion about their country's democratic future is itself the condition demobilization by subtraction predicts.

The alternative mechanisms section has addressed the pandemic, generational, and preference-falsification concerns; these factors may amplify specific estimates but cannot account for the overall pattern. Any single-country study faces inherent limits of generalizability: the mechanisms identified here may reflect Cambodia's particular configuration of post-conflict politics, dominant-party rule, and opposition dynamics. Whether subtraction operates similarly in other dominant-party or post-competitive contexts is now, at least, a researchable question.

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The author used Claude (Anthropic, version 4.5) to assist with R programming, including data cleaning scripts, model specification, and debugging of analysis code. All analytical decisions, theoretical framing, and interpretation of results are the author's own. AI-generated code was reviewed, tested, and modified by the author before inclusion in the analysis pipeline.

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